The Fourteen Points

President Woodrow Wilson · Address to Joint Session of Congress · January 8, 1918

Source: Avalon Project (Yale Law School), avalon.law.yale.edu/20th_century/wilson14.asp.

Wilson laid out his vision for a post-war peace nine months before the Armistice. The plan called for open diplomacy, freedom of the seas, free trade, disarmament, self-determination for European nationalities, and — point fourteen — a 'general association of nations' that became the League of Nations. The U.S. Senate rejected the Treaty of Versailles in 1919–20 and the U.S. never joined the League.

Connect: Wilson pushed the League of Nations while the Senate refused. This isn't the first time Congress checked a president's foreign policy. Compare with Washington's Farewell warnings (Class 7).

Key Passages

Wilson's framing

> What we demand in this war, therefore, is nothing peculiar to ourselves. It is that the world be made fit and safe to live in; and particularly that it be made safe for every peace-loving nation which … wishes to live its own life, determine its own institutions, be assured of justice and fair dealing by the other peoples of the world.

Selected points

> I. Open covenants of peace, openly arrived at. II. Absolute freedom of navigation upon the seas. III. The removal, so far as possible, of all economic barriers. IV. Adequate guarantees … that national armaments will be reduced. V. A free, open-minded, and absolutely impartial adjustment of all colonial claims.

Point XIV — League of Nations

> XIV. A general association of nations must be formed under specific covenants for the purpose of affording mutual guarantees of political independence and territorial integrity to great and small states alike.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	The U.S. had entered World War I (1917); Russia's Bolsheviks had published secret Allied treaties, and nations debated what the postwar peace would look like.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress, the American public, the Allies and Central Powers, and peoples seeking independence; it was a speech to Congress meant for the world.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President Woodrow Wilson, an idealist and progressive who believed in self-determination and collective security; colonized peoples outside Europe were largely overlooked.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Evidence Beyond Docs (1 pt): Identify TWO outside pieces of evidence (people, events, treaties) you could use in an essay about Wilson and the post-WWI settlement.

2. Why did the U.S. Senate reject the Treaty of Versailles? Identify the key senator and his core objection.

3. Trace ONE specific Fourteen Point that DID survive — at the Paris conference or in later international law.